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Units that are both weights and monetary values

11.2 Units that are both weights and monetary values

Shekel

11.2.1 Shekel

References:

Hebrew שֶׁקֶל (sheqel) GEN 23:15, GEN 23:16, EXO 21:32, EXO 30:13, EXO 30:13, EXO 30:13, EXO 30:13, EXO 30:15, EXO 30:24, EXO 38:24, EXO 38:24, EXO 38:25, EXO 38:25, EXO 38:26, EXO 38:26, EXO 38:29, LEV 5:15, LEV 5:15, LEV 27:3, LEV 27:3, LEV 27:4, LEV 27:5, LEV 27:5, LEV 27:6, LEV 27:6, LEV 27:7, LEV 27:7, LEV 27:16, LEV 27:25, LEV 27:25, NUM 3:47, NUM 3:47, NUM 3:47, NUM 3:50, NUM 7:13, NUM 7:13, NUM 7:19, NUM 7:19, NUM 7:25, NUM 7:25, NUM 7:31, NUM 7:31, NUM 7:37, NUM 7:37, NUM 7:43, NUM 7:43, NUM 7:49, NUM 7:49, NUM 7:55, NUM 7:55, NUM 7:61, NUM 7:61, NUM 7:67, NUM 7:67, NUM 7:73, NUM 7:73, NUM 7:79, NUM 7:79, NUM 7:85, NUM 7:86, NUM 18:16, NUM 18:16, NUM 31:52, JOS 7:21, JOS 7:21, 1SA 9:8, 1SA 17:5, 1SA 17:7, 2SA 14:26, 2SA 24:24, 2KI 7:1, 2KI 7:1, 2KI 7:16, 2KI 7:16, 2KI 7:18, 2KI 7:18, 2KI 15:20, 1CH 21:25, 2CH 3:9, NEH 5:15, NEH 10:33, JER 32:9, EZK 4:10, EZK 45:12, EZK 45:12, EZK 45:12, EZK 45:12, AMO 8:5

Aramaic תְּקֵל (teqel) DAN 5:25, DAN 5:27

The Hebrew word sheqel means “weight,” and the system of weights in ancient Israel was based on it.

According to Fry, we should treat the shekel according to three different time periods: (1) through the time of David, it was like the New Testament denarius, which equaled a day’s wage; (2) from the time of Solomon to the captivity, the shekel was 1/10 of the old value; (3) from the captivity onward there was again a devaluation, so a month’s wages was 20 shekels (equaling 1 daric). In the Old Testament where the word “shekel” refers to money, the passages can be divided as follows according to the meaning of “shekel”:

1. One day’s wage equals one shekel: GEN 23:15; GEN 23:16; EXO 21:32; NUM 31:52; JOS 7:21; JOS 7:21; 1SA 9:8; 1SA 17:5; 1SA 17:7; 2SA 14:26; 2SA 24:24; 1CH 21:25
2. One day’s wage equals 10 shekels: 2KI 7:1; 2KI 7:1; 2KI 7:16; 2KI 7:16; 2KI 7:18; 2KI 7:18; 2KI 15:20; 2CH 3:9; AMO 8:5
3. One day’s wage equals 20 shekels: JER 32:9; EZK 4:10; EZK 45:12; EZK 45:12; EZK 45:12; EZK 45:12

The word “shekel” refers to regular weight in GEN 23:15; GEN 23:16; EXO 21:32 and in more than twenty other passages.

The word “shekel” refers to double weight (sheqel haqodesh; literally “the holy shekel,” which is rendered “shekel of the sanctuary” by RSV) in the following Old Testament passages: EXO 30:13; EXO 30:13; EXO 30:13; EXO 30:13; EXO 30:15; EXO 30:24; EXO 38:24; EXO 38:24; EXO 38:25; EXO 38:25; EXO 38:26; EXO 38:26; EXO 38:29; LEV 5:15; LEV 5:15; LEV 27:3; LEV 27:3; LEV 27:4; LEV 27:5; LEV 27:5; LEV 27:6; LEV 27:6; LEV 27:7; LEV 27:7; LEV 27:16; LEV 27:25; LEV 27:25; NUM 3:47; NUM 3:47; NUM 3:50; NUM 7:13; NUM 7:13; NUM 7:19; NUM 7:19; NUM 7:25; NUM 7:25; NUM 7:31; NUM 7:31; NUM 7:37; NUM 7:37; NUM 7:43; NUM 7:43; NUM 7:49; NUM 7:49; NUM 7:55; NUM 7:55; NUM 7:61; NUM 7:61; NUM 7:67; NUM 7:67; NUM 7:73; NUM 7:73; NUM 7:79; NUM 7:79; NUM 7:85; NUM 7:86; NUM 18:16; NUM 18:16. There seems to have been a separate standard of weight used in the service of the Tabernacle. While its exact or even relative value is not given in Scripture, many scholars believe that it was double the weight of the shekel used in ordinary commerce. GNT renders the literal expression “the shekel of the sanctuary” as “according to the official standard.” But it is probably better to add to this “... of the sanctuary” for the sake of clarity. Also, the religious component may have been significant in that some degree of consistency would have been used in such measures. Other ways of expressing the idea of a special weight/value used for religious purposes in a passage like EXO 30:13 are “according to the official standards” (CEV), “using the standard weight of the holy place” (GW), and “according to the unit of weight which is in force in the sanctuary” (ITCL).

For the Aramaic word teqel in DAN 5:25; DAN 5:27, see the discussion under peres above, 11.1.4 Peres, Parsin<REALIA:11.1.4>.

Mina

11.2.2 Mina

References:

Hebrew מָנֶה (maneh) 1KI 10:17, EZR 2:69, NEH 7:70, NEH 7:71, EZK 45:12

Aramaic מְנָא (mne') DAN 5:25, DAN 5:25, DAN 5:26

Greek μνᾶ (mna) LUK 19:13, LUK 19:16, LUK 19:16, LUK 19:18, LUK 19:18, LUK 19:20, LUK 19:24, LUK 19:24, LUK 19:25, 1MA 14:24, 1MA 15:18, 3MA 1:4, 1ES 5:44, 1ES 5:44

The above words refer to the mina. According to most authorities, the maneh was equal to 50 shekels, and there were 60 minas in a talent. Some authorities, however, say there were 60 shekels in a mina and 50 minas in a talent (see EZK 45:12).

1KI 10:17: The weight of a gold shield is given as "three minas" (RSV) in this verse. Most common-language translations have a modern weight equivalent, for example, "almost four pounds" (CEV) and "almost two kilograms" (ITCL).

EZR 2:69; NEH 7:70; NEH 7:71: Translators generally give the amounts here for the word maneh in minas (with or without a note), or they give a modern weight equivalent. In EZR 2:69 for the literal phrase "five thousand minas of silver" (RSV), SPCL is a bit heavy, writing out "two thousand seven hundred and fifty kilos of silver." NCV rounds off the figure to the same number of significant figures as the original text, saying "about 6000 pounds of silver."

EZK 45:12 defines one mina as 60 shekels. This is unusual in Scripture, and it may represent a purposefully higher "royal" figure.

LUK 19:13; LUK 19:16; LUK 19:16; LUK 19:18; LUK 19:18; LUK 19:20; LUK 19:24; LUK 19:24; LUK 19:25: The amount given to the servants in this parable almost certainly represents a sum of money and not a weight. The precise value of this money is not in focus here but rather what three of the servants did with what they received. It may be helpful to keep in mind that one mna was approximately equal to the wages of a day laborer for four months. While the exact amount is not important, it is significant that they each received the same amount. CEV seems to obscure this point by rendering the second clause in LUK 19:13 as "gave each of them some money" (similarly REB). Here the model of ITCL is preferable: "he gave each of them the same amount of money." NCV renders mna as "a coin," but this is misleading since no country today has in circulation a coin of such high value. Its footnote does explain that it was a large sum of money, but inaccurately states the amount to be three months' wages. GNT "a gold coin" is only slightly better. Better still is "a large sum of money" (SPCLITCL).

For the Aramaic word mne' in DAN 5:25; DAN 5:25; DAN 5:26, see the discussion under peres above, 11.1.4 Peres, Parsin<REALIA:11.1.4>.

Talent

11.2.3 Talent

References:

Hebrew כִּכָּר (kikar) EXO 25:39, EXO 37:24, EXO 38:24, EXO 38:25, EXO 38:27, EXO 38:27, EXO 38:27, EXO 38:29, 2SA 12:30, 1KI 9:14, 1KI 9:28, 1KI 10:10, 1KI 10:14, 1KI 16:24, 1KI 20:39, 2KI 5:5, 2KI 5:22, 2KI 5:23, 2KI 5:23, 2KI 15:19, 2KI 18:14, 2KI 18:14, 2KI 23:33, 2KI 23:33, 1CH 19:6, 1CH 20:2, 1CH 22:14, 1CH 22:14, 1CH 29:4, 1CH 29:4, 1CH 29:7, 1CH 29:7, 1CH 29:7, 1CH 29:7, 2CH 3:8, 2CH 8:18, 2CH 9:9, 2CH 9:13, 2CH 25:6, 2CH 25:9, 2CH 27:5, 2CH 36:3, 2CH 36:3, EZR 8:26, EZR 8:26, EZR 8:26, EST 3:9

Aramaic כִּכַּר (kakar) EZR 7:22

Greek τάλαντον (talanton) MAT 18:24, MAT 25:15, MAT 25:16, MAT 25:20, MAT 25:20, MAT 25:20, MAT 25:20, MAT 25:22, MAT 25:22, MAT 25:22, MAT 25:24, MAT 25:25, MAT 25:28, MAT 25:28, TOB 1:14, TOB 4:20, ESG 3:9, ESG 4:7, 1MA 11:28,

system that prevailed at a particular period of time. A silver talentsystem that prevailed at a particular period of time. A silver talent was worth approximately 6000 denarii and a gold talent was worthwas worth approximately 6000 denarii and a gold talent was worth at least thirty times that much. at least thirty times that much.

1MA 13:16, 1MA 13:19, 1MA 15:31, 1MA 15:31, 1MA 15:35, 2MA 3:11, 2MA 4:8, 2MA 4:8, 2MA 4:24, 2MA 5:21, 2MA 8:10, 2MA 8:11, 4MA 4:17, 1ES 1:34, 1ES 1:34, 1ES 3:21, 1ES 4:51, 1ES 4:52, 1ES 8:19, 1ES 8:56, 1ES 8:56, 1ES 8:56

Greek ταλαντιαῖος (talantiaios) REV 16:21

The above words refer to the talent. Basically the talent was the largest unit of weight in the ancient world, equal to about 34 kilograms (75 pounds). Later it was used as a monetary unit with a value that fluctuated, depending upon the particular monetary system that prevailed at a particular period of time. A silver talent was worth approximately 6000 denarii and a gold talent was worth at least thirty times that much.

There was no such coin as a talent, which had too high a value.

MAT 18:21–MAT 18:35: In this parable the significance of the amount of the debts of the two servants is not in their precise value but rather in the huge difference between them. There seems to be a secondary significance to the size of the debt of the first servant, hinting at the great debt of sin that Jesus' hearers have toward God. The amount of the large debt would be something like the salaries of 1,000 day laborers for 20 years. However, it would be awkward to try to include this information in the translation itself. The Greek text compares two different monetary instruments, the talent and the denarius. While the ancient hearer may have known that a talent was equal to 6000 denarii, this knowledge cannot be assumed for the modern reader. One effective way to emphasize the difference between the two debts may be to convert the 10,000 talents into denarii and render the last half of verse 24 as "one of them was brought in who owed him 60 million denarii." This will then contrast with the 100 denarii in verse 28. This may be a problem in cultures where very large numbers are difficult to express. In such cultures translators may follow GNT "millions of dollars ... a few dollars" or PV "millions of silver pieces ... 100 pieces of silver."

MAT 25:14–MAT 25:30: The actual value of the talent in this parable is of secondary importance. It is of primary importance to retain the 5:2:1 ratio. Numerous ways have been found in translation to express the amount given to each servant. Here are a few examples for the first half of verse 15: "he handed five thousand coins to the first servant, two thousand to the second, and one thousand to the third" (CEV); "He gave one man ten thousand dollars, another four thousand dollars, and another two thousand dollars" (GW); "He gave one servant five bags of gold, another servant two bags of gold, and a third servant one bag of gold" (NCV); and "to one he gave five thousand gold coins, to another he gave two thousand, and to another he gave one thousand" (GNT).

Translations do not agree as to whether the master gave them gold or silver. While this makes considerable difference in the values, it does not affect the meaning of the text and so makes no difference to the translation. A particular metal should be included only if it is required by the language. The context in which this parable occurs is different from that in which the parallel in LUK 19:11–LUK 19:27 appears. Furthermore, Luke gives the amounts in minas while Matthew has talents, which were worth 60 times as much. While the translator does not need to find a precise modern currency equivalent, the amount chosen in Matthew should indicate that these were large sums of money.

REV 16:21: In this verse many translations render the literal phrase "about a talent" as "about 40 kilograms" (FRCL) or "about a hundred pounds" (NIV). In languages that have a limited group of numbers it will be better to begin this verse with "Huge hailstones of tremendous weight [or, weighing as much as an adult person]." In fact, it will be quite adequate to follow the model of Phps "Great hailstones like heavy weights" or GW "Large, heavy hailstones."